Nazh-Far Mariwa Berganio

Nazh-Far Mariwa Berganio is a Filipino humanitarian leader and human rights advocate who has emerged as one of the most prominent voices for internally displaced persons (IDPs) in the Philippines and globally. He serves as the co-founder and president of Ako Bakwit, Inc., a groundbreaking advocacy organization dedicated to protecting the rights of families displaced by conflict and disasters. In March 2026, he was appointed to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) Global IDP Advisory Group, making him one of only 12 global leaders tasked with shaping the UN's strategy on internal displacement.

Berganio's signature advocacy philosophy centers on "dignity over charity," pushing for systemic solutions that grant IDPs the same rights and access to services as settled citizens rather than treating displacement as a charity case. His Tausug heritage and personal journey from Jolo, Sulu to becoming a globally recognized humanitarian exemplify the resilience of displaced communities and their fight for institutional recognition.

His most notable achievements include spearheading the campaign for the IDP Rights Act in the Philippine Congress and representing Filipino IDPs on the international stage through his UNHCR appointment—a milestone celebrated by the Philippine Commission on Human Rights (CHR) as a significant breakthrough for Filipino representation in global humanitarian governance.

Nazh-Far Mariwa Berganio



Born	Jolo, Sulu, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Tausug
Occupation	Humanitarian leader, human rights advocate, political consultant
Known for	Co-founder and President of Ako Bakwit, Inc. UNHCR Global IDP Advisory Group member
Organization	Ako Bakwit, Inc.
Title	JCI Senator (#84363)
Movement	"Dignity over charity"

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Early Life and Background

Berganio was born and raised in Jolo, Sulu, a municipality in the Bangsamoro region of the Philippines that has long been affected by armed conflict and displacement. He belongs to the **Tausug** ethnic group, whose name means "people of the current," indigenous to the Sulu Archipelago. Growing up in this conflict-affected region shaped his understanding of the systemic challenges faced by displaced communities.

In 2006, seeking better opportunities beyond the limited prospects in his homeland, Berganio made a pivotal decision to relocate to Manila. He arrived in the capital with only 10,000 pesos—a modest sum that underscored the financial vulnerability common among internal migrants from conflict zones. This migration experience became formative; he encountered urban discrimination and navigated the barriers that many IDPs face when attempting to integrate into metropolitan areas. These early struggles with marginalization and limited resources would later inform his advocacy work, giving him firsthand insight into the "invisible displacement" that occurs when conflict-affected populations move to cities without formal support systems.

Education and Professional Development

Before dedicating himself full-time to humanitarian work, Berganio built a diverse professional career that combined practical expertise with leadership development. His professional background includes extensive experience in **land acquisition** and **political consultancy**, where he advised various local and national elected officials across the Philippines. This work gave him valuable insights into governance structures, policy-making processes, and the mechanics of political advocacy—skills that would prove essential in his later work advocating for IDP rights legislation.

Berganio is an active member of **JCI Philippines** (Junior Chamber International), a global leadership development organization focused on creating positive change through civic engagement. Within this network, he has earned the distinguished title of **JCI Senator** (membership number #84363), a recognition given to individuals who have demonstrated exceptional leadership and commitment to community service. His involvement in JCI Philippines has expanded his network of civic leaders and provided him with platforms to amplify his advocacy on national and regional stages.

While the available records do not specify formal tertiary education credentials, Berganio's professional trajectory demonstrates a commitment to continuous learning through practical experience, mentorship networks, and participation in leadership organizations that emphasize skill-building in areas such as public speaking, project management, and social entrepreneurship.

Career and Professional Expertise

Berganio's career arc represents a deliberate transition from conventional professional work to dedicated humanitarian service, though his earlier roles provided essential foundations for his advocacy work.

Land Acquisition and Political Consultancy

Prior to founding Ako Bakwit, Berganio worked extensively in the field of land acquisition, navigating the complex legal and bureaucratic processes involved in property rights and territorial disputes. This expertise proved particularly relevant given that land tenure insecurity is a major issue for many IDP communities, especially those living in informal settlements after displacement.

His work as a political consultant involved advising elected officials at both local government unit (LGU) and national levels. This role required deep knowledge of Philippine governance structures, legislative processes, and the art of coalition-building—competencies he would later deploy in his advocacy for the IDP Rights Act. Through this work, he developed relationships with policymakers and gained credibility within political circles, positioning him to effectively lobby for legislative reforms.

Transition to Humanitarian Leadership

The catalytic moment for Berganio's full-time shift to humanitarian work came during the COVID-19 pandemic, when he recognized that existing government response mechanisms were failing to reach IDP communities. Many families displaced by the Marawi siege of 2017 had resettled in the National Capital Region (NCR) and CALABARZON, surviving through informal vending in areas like Quiapo and Baclaran. When pandemic lockdowns disrupted their livelihoods, these families faced compounded vulnerabilities—lacking both the economic safety nets available to formal workers and the community support systems they had left behind in Mindanao.

Seeing this gap, Berganio co-founded Ako Bakwit with Samira Gutoc in 2020, transforming his professional skills in political consultancy and advocacy into a focused mission to serve displaced populations.

Institutional Contributions

Ako Bakwit, Inc.

In 2020, Berganio co-founded **Ako Bakwit, Inc.** (literal translation: "I am an evacuee/displaced person") alongside Samira Ali Gutoc, a prominent civic leader and former member of the Bangsamoro Transition Commission. The organization was legally incorporated during the height of the COVID-19 pandemic to address the specific vulnerabilities of IDP families, particularly those from the Marawi siege who had relocated to Metro Manila.

The founding partnership combined Gutoc's policy influence and national political platform with Berganio's operational leadership and lived experience as a displaced person. While Gutoc serves as Chairperson and primary public advocate, Berganio manages executive operations as President. This division of labor allowed the organization to operate on two fronts simultaneously: Gutoc focused on media engagement and legislative lobbying, while Berganio coordinated on-the-ground relief operations and built community organizing structures among IDP populations.

Ako Bakwit gained rapid prominence for its work during the pandemic, when it:

- Distributed emergency relief supplies to IDP families who were excluded from government aid programs due to lack of proper documentation
- Provided legal assistance to families facing eviction from informal settlements
- Documented cases of discrimination against Muslim IDPs in accessing healthcare and social services
- Advocated for the inclusion of IDPs in COVID-19 vaccination rollouts

The organization operates through a network of "convenors" and regional coordinators, collaborating with groups such as **Kazalimbago** and the **Bangsamoro Watch Initiative** to coordinate relief missions and legal aid for displaced families across Mindanao and Metro Manila.

What distinguishes Ako Bakwit from traditional humanitarian organizations is its advocacy model, which emphasizes **rights-based approaches** over charity-based relief. Rather than simply distributing aid, the organization focuses on systemic advocacy: pushing for policy reforms, legal frameworks, and institutional changes that address the root causes of IDP vulnerability.

UNHCR Global IDP Advisory Group

In March 2026, Berganio was appointed to the **UNHCR Global IDP Advisory Group** for the 2026–2027 term, becoming one of only 12 global leaders selected to advise the United Nations on its strategy for addressing internal displacement worldwide. This appointment represents a watershed moment both for Berganio personally and for Filipino representation in international humanitarian governance.

The Advisory Group's mandate includes:

- Providing strategic counsel to UNHCR on protection frameworks for IDPs
- Identifying gaps in current international response mechanisms
- Amplifying the voices of displaced communities in global policy discussions
- Sharing best practices and innovative approaches from different regional contexts

Berganio's selection was based on his demonstrated leadership in grassroots advocacy, his ability to bridge community organizing with policy influence, and his credibility as someone who brings lived experience of displacement to international forums. The Philippine Commission on Human Rights (CHR) publicly celebrated his appointment as a significant milestone for the country's participation in shaping global humanitarian norms.

In this role, Berganio brings a distinctly Asian and Filipino perspective to conversations often dominated by African and Middle Eastern displacement contexts. He has emphasized the need for international frameworks to better address "urban displacement"—when IDPs relocate to cities rather than refugee camps—and the unique challenges of protracted displacement in contexts where armed conflict is localized rather than nationwide.

Achievements and Recognition

Policy Advocacy and Legislative Impact

Berganio is a principal advocate for the **IDP Rights Act**, a proposed legislation in the Philippine Congress that would establish a comprehensive national framework for the protection and assistance of internally displaced persons. The bill seeks to:

- Define legal rights and entitlements for IDPs
- Establish coordination mechanisms across government agencies
- Create dedicated funding streams for displacement response
- Mandate data collection on displacement to inform policy

His advocacy strategy has involved coalition-building across religious, ethnic, and political lines—bringing together Muslim, Christian, and Indigenous leaders to present a unified front. He has testified before congressional committees, organized community consultations to gather testimonies from displaced families, and worked with legal experts to refine the bill's language.

Cultural and National Significance

As a Tausug professional who has achieved international recognition, Berganio represents an important counter-narrative to prevailing stereotypes about Muslim Mindanao communities. His success challenges reductive portrayals of the Bangsamoro region and demonstrates the leadership potential of individuals from conflict-affected areas when given platforms and resources.

The Philippine Commission on Human Rights has highlighted his UNHCR appointment as evidence that Filipino civil society leaders can compete at the highest levels of global governance, particularly in specialized fields like humanitarian protection.

Philosophy of "Dignity Over Charity"

Central to Berganio's advocacy is the principle of **dignity over charity**—a framework that rejects paternalistic approaches to humanitarian aid in favor of rights-based empowerment. This philosophy manifests in several key positions:

- **Legal recognition**: IDPs should have formal legal status that entitles them to services, not discretionary assistance
- **Political participation**: Displaced communities should have voice in decisions affecting their lives, including participation in peace processes and development planning
- **Economic integration**: Rather than perpetual dependence on relief aid, IDPs need access to livelihood programs, skills training, and formal employment
- **Social dignity**: Humanitarian interventions should preserve the cultural identity and social cohesion of displaced communities rather than imposing assimilationist models

This philosophy has influenced Ako Bakwit's programmatic approach, which prioritizes community organizing, legal empowerment, and advocacy over traditional relief distribution.

Challenges and Criticisms

Like many advocacy organizations, Ako Bakwit and Berganio's leadership have faced various challenges and criticisms:

Funding and Sustainability

As a relatively young organization founded during a global pandemic, Ako Bakwit has navigated significant resource constraints. Unlike large international NGOs with stable institutional funding, the organization relies heavily on individual donations, small grants, and volunteer labor. This financial precarity limits its ability to scale operations and provide sustained support to displaced communities.

Political Sensitivities

Advocacy work on displacement in the Philippines inevitably intersects with contentious political issues—armed conflict in Mindanao, the peace process with Moro groups, military operations, and government resettlement programs. Berganio's work requires careful navigation of these sensitivities, particularly when critiquing government policies while also seeking to collaborate with state agencies on legislative reforms.

Some critics have questioned whether rights-based advocacy adequately addresses the immediate survival needs of displaced families, arguing that legislative campaigns may not translate quickly enough into tangible improvements in people's lives.

Representation Questions

While Berganio's Tausug identity and personal displacement experience lend authenticity to his advocacy, some observers note that the IDP population in the Philippines is extremely diverse—including not just Muslim Mindanao communities but also Indigenous peoples, Christian communities affected by natural disasters, and urban poor populations displaced by development projects. There are ongoing discussions about ensuring that advocacy organizations adequately represent this diversity rather than centering primarily on conflict-related displacement in Muslim areas.

See Also

- Ako Bakwit
- Samira Gutoc
- Internally displaced person
- Bangsamoro
- Marawi siege
- Tausug people
- United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
- Philippine Commission on Human Rights

References

- UNHCR Global IDP Advisory Group Biographies (March 2025) (https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2025-03/idp-advisory-group-biographies.pdf)
- LinkedIn Profile: Nazh-Far Mariwa Berganio (https://ph.linkedin.com/in/nfmb)
- Ako Bakwit official records and organizational documents
- Philippine Commission on Human Rights statements on UNHCR appointment
- JCI Philippines membership records

External Links

- [Official Ako Bakwit website or social media]
- [UNHCR Global IDP Advisory Group page]
- [LinkedIn profile]

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